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ARTICLE

School Is Out. Vacation Bible School Is In.



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BY PNW STAFF JUNE 30, 2026

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As classrooms empty and the final school bells fade into memory, something remarkable begins unfolding across America. Church parking lots fill with colorful decorations. Fellowship halls are transformed into jungles, castles, space stations, western towns, and underwater adventures. Volunteers spend countless hours cutting cardboard, painting murals, preparing snacks, rehearsing songs, and praying over the children who will soon walk through their doors.

It is Vacation Bible School season once again.

For millions of Americans, VBS isn't just another summer activity. It is one of the most enduring traditions in Christian life--a week that many adults still remember decades later. Long after children forget their summer camps, sports leagues, or video games, many can still sing the songs they learned at Vacation Bible School, recall Bible verses they memorized, or remember the teacher who first explained God's love in a way they could understand.

That kind of lasting impact doesn't happen by accident.

Vacation Bible School has been quietly shaping generations of Americans for more than 125 years.

Its roots stretch back to the late nineteenth century. In 1894, Sunday school teacher D.T. Miles began one of the earliest daily Bible schools in Hopedale, Illinois. A few years later, in 1898, Virginia Sinclair Hawes saw a growing need among children in New York City's crowded neighborhoods. Rather than waiting for children to come to church, she rented a beer hall on the city's East Side and transformed it into an "Everyday Bible School," bringing Bible stories, songs, and Christian instruction directly into the community.



It was an unlikely location for ministry--but perhaps the perfect reminder that God often works in unexpected places.

The movement continued to grow. Robert Boville expanded the concept through the New York City Baptist Mission Society in the early 1900s, while Southern Baptist pastor Homer Grice helped establish the modern format in the 1920s. In 1924, what is now Lifeway Christian Resources created a dedicated Vacation Bible School department, helping churches across America organize programs that continue to this day.

More than a century later, the idea has not merely survived--it has flourished.

According to Lifeway, its VBS curriculum alone reaches more than 2.5 million children and adults every summer through over 25,000 churches. Southern Baptist churches reported more than 1.66 million enrollments in 2025, representing significant growth over the previous year. Baptist churches remain some of the largest participants, but Lutheran, Presbyterian, Methodist, non-denominational churches, and even some Catholic parishes now host similar summer Bible programs.

Perhaps even more remarkable is how deeply VBS has become woven into American culture.

Six out of ten American adults attended Vacation Bible School as children. Nine out of ten remember the experience positively. Nearly seventy percent of today's parents say they would send their own children if invited by a friend.

Think about that for a moment.

In a society where entertainment trends come and go with astonishing speed, Vacation Bible School has remained relevant across four or five generations. Very few children's programs can claim that kind of longevity.

Why?

Because while the decorations change each year, the message never does.

Today's children may learn Bible lessons aboard imaginary pirate ships, race cars, mountain expeditions, or outer space adventures, but beneath the colorful themes lies the same eternal truth that has anchored Christianity for two thousand years. They hear about creation, Noah, David, Daniel, the cross, the resurrection, and the saving grace found in Jesus Christ.



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Along the way they memorize Scripture, sing worship songs, make crafts, play games, enjoy snacks, and build friendships.

To an outside observer it may simply look like organized fun.

To the church, it is intentional discipleship.

And perhaps that matters now more than ever.

American children are growing up in a culture increasingly hostile--or at best indifferent--to biblical truth. They are bombarded daily by social media influencers, streaming platforms, online gaming communities, and educational systems that often promote worldviews far removed from Christianity. Children today consume more digital content than any generation before them.

Which raises an important question.

If the world spends thousands of hours discipling our children, shouldn't the church eagerly seize every opportunity to do the same?

Vacation Bible School provides one answer.

It offers something increasingly rare: adults who intentionally invest in children with no agenda other than pointing them toward Christ. Hundreds of thousands of volunteers sacrifice vacation time, work evenings preparing lessons, decorate classrooms, lead worship, teach crafts, supervise games, and pray for children they may never see again after that week ends.

Many receive little recognition.

But eternity may reveal just how significant their service truly was.

History is filled with pastors, missionaries, evangelists, and faithful believers who trace their spiritual journey back to a simple invitation to Vacation Bible School. Some first heard the Gospel there. Others accepted Christ during VBS. Many developed lifelong friendships with

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But _____,

And seeds have a way of growing.

As churches across America once again throw open their doors this summer, Christians should remember that Vacation Bible School is far more than an annual tradition. It is one of the church's greatest evangelistic opportunities. It is one week where neighborhoods often gladly send children into churches that they might never attend on a Sunday morning.

What an incredible privilege.

So while children laugh through obstacle courses, sing energetic songs, glue together colorful crafts, and enjoy cookies and punch, something far more important is happening beneath the surface. Hearts are being shaped. Scripture is being hidden away in young minds. The Gospel is being proclaimed.

In an age obsessed with the next new thing, perhaps one of America's greatest summer traditions reminds us that God's timeless truth never goes out of season.

School may be out.

But for thousands of churches across America, one of the most important classrooms of the year has just opened its doors.

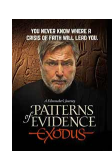
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